

Comment: b) and c) differ from a) only in a similar sounding vowel, while variants 8 and 14 involve a single letter. There is a small sub-group (with fuzzy edges) based on variants 17, 20, 29. There is a larger, fuzzier group that has variants 1, 16, 17, 28, 29 as sort of a basis, with 9, 19 on the fringes, and then further variation. There are 40-50 MSS with varying amounts of mixture added to an **M**⁷ base (adding these to the unambiguous ones and dividing by 1650 we come out with about 18%). Actually, I believe that **M**⁷ was the base from which the creators of **M**⁵ and **M**⁶ (and all other groups) departed.

Interpretative comment: The progressive ‘purification’ of the stream of transmission through the centuries (from a Byzantine priority perspective) has been recognized by all and sundry, their attempts at explaining the phenomenon generally reflecting their presuppositions. From my point of view the evident explanation is this: All camps recognize that the heaviest attacks against the purity of the Text took place during the second century. But ‘the heartland of the Church’, the Aegean area, by far the best qualified in every way to watch over the faithful transmission, simply refused to copy the aberrant forms. MSS containing such forms were not used (nor copied), so many survived physically for over a millennium. Less bad forms were used (copies were hard to come by) but progressively were not copied. Thus the surviving IX century uncials are fair, over 80% Byzantine, but not good enough to be copied and recycled (when the better MSS were put into minuscule form). Until the advent of a printed text, MSS were made to be used. Progressively only the best were used, and thus worn out, and copied. This process culminated in the XIV century, when the Ottoman shadow was advancing over Asia Minor, but the Byzantine empire still stood.

Please note the ‘from a Byzantine priority perspective’. **Family 35 was copied faithfully from beginning to end.** For seventeen books I myself have a single perfect copy done in the 15th century (besides a variety of copies that are perfect for one or more books, from the 14th, 13th, 12th and 11th). For a copy done in the 15th to be perfect, all of its ‘ancestors’ had to be perfect as well. Please note that a perfect copy makes all the ‘canons’ of textual criticism irrelevant to any point subsequent to the creation of the archetype. But how can we know that a given copy is ‘perfect’? The archetypal profile can be empirically established by comparing all the extant family representatives (I am referring to **f**³⁵ only). A copy that matches the archetype perfectly is a perfect copy, of necessity. But perfect copies tell us something important about the attitude of the copyists. That they should do their work with such care presumably indicates at least respect, if not reverence toward what they were copying—they believed